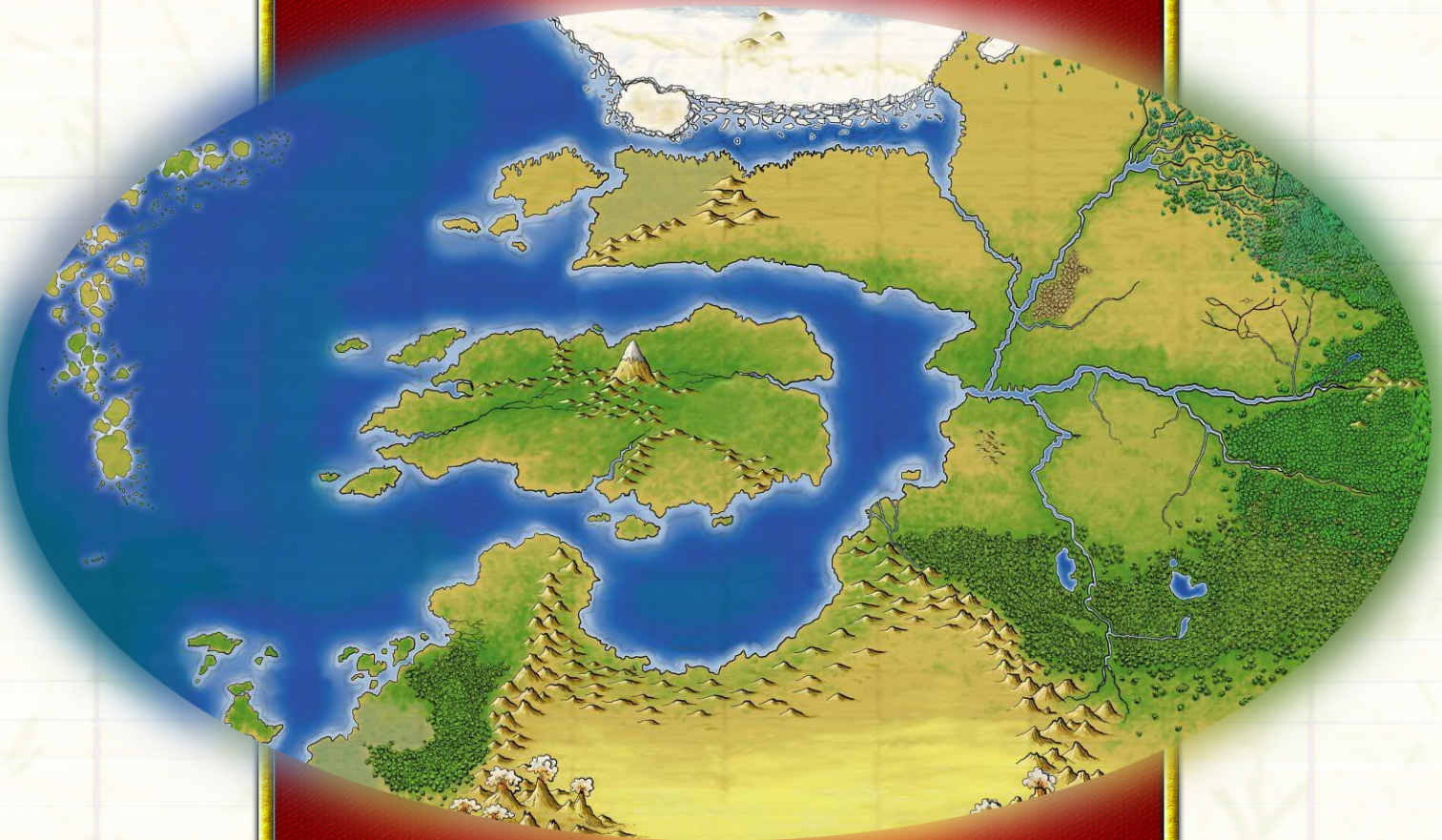




A BRIEF HISTORY OF CREATION



by Caleb Wichman

In the Beginning...

There was **Chaos**. The *essence* of reality swirled in and through itself with neither rhyme nor reason. Time and space were meaningless, matter and energy had no substance, existence itself was made only of potential: concepts of things that were not, but might yet be. This was the **Wyld**.

The Shinma

Out of this chaos, some pockets began to form, gaps between concepts. These pockets of emptiness began to define the chaos by opposition, shaping what was through what they were not. These were the **Shinma**.

Nirguna, the Heart, does not exist, has no substance or form, and so, by not being her, other things are able to be.

Nirupadhika, the Way, has no location, is everywhere and nowhere, and so, by not being her, other things are able to be in one place and not in another.

Niramytha, the Age, has no beginning or end, no past or future, and so, by not being her, other things are able to change with time.

Nirvishesha, the Ring, has no identity, no differentiation or border, and so, by not being her, other things are able to be separate and individual.

Nirvikalpa, the Staff, does not interact, has no connection to anything else, and so, by not being her, other things are able to perceive and affect yet other things.

Dharma, the Cup, is perfect and pure, has no blemishes and makes no mistakes, and so, by not being her, other things are able to be flawed.

Nishkriya, the Sword, is unimpeded, has no obstacles or conflict, and so, by not being her, other things are able to struggle and compete.

Arcadia

As these Shinma came into nonbeing, the chaos around them was influenced in opposition to their absence, and as their influences grew, they began to overlap. At the center of this metaphysical influence, where things could have form and location and identity and all of the things the Shinma were not, there became enough order in the chaos that more complex concepts started to crystallize. There started to be things like individual beings, places, and events. As these concepts interacted and overlapped, they started to take the form of *Stories*. These stories had characters and settings, and both of these things were alive. The settings were called the **Unshaped**, and the characters were called the **Raksha**, or "*Fair Folk*".

The Fair Folk, over time, developed more and more complex stories, and as they crossed over with each other they began to establish shared canon: recurring themes, stable locations, memorable events. Eventually there began to be something like a world amidst the chaos of the Wyld. This was **Arcadia**, the great kingdom of the Fair Folk.

The Primordials

Now, even in the overlapping influence of the Shinma, this was still the Deep Wyld, and chaos constantly stormed through Arcadia. Raksha sprang into being, quested through stories, and were swept away into nothingness, all at the whims of the winds of the Wyld.

Then one day, out of the chaos came a new kind of being, sharing similarities with Shinma, Unshaped, and Raksha, but ultimately different from all of these things.

Like Shinma, they existed as concepts, and gave shape to reality simply through being. Yet unlike Shinma, they created their concept by embodying it, by being it rather than by being in opposition to it.

Like Unshaped, their forms were vast, in some cases infinite, their bodies being more like continents to the Raksha, or even entire worlds. Yet unlike Unshaped, their forms were solid, anchored by set relative distances between points rather than by the flow of narrative causality.

Like Raksha, they had character and personality, names and desires and personal history. Yet unlike the Raksha, they did not exist for the sake of filling a role in a narrative; rather they seemed to have an actual will of their own.

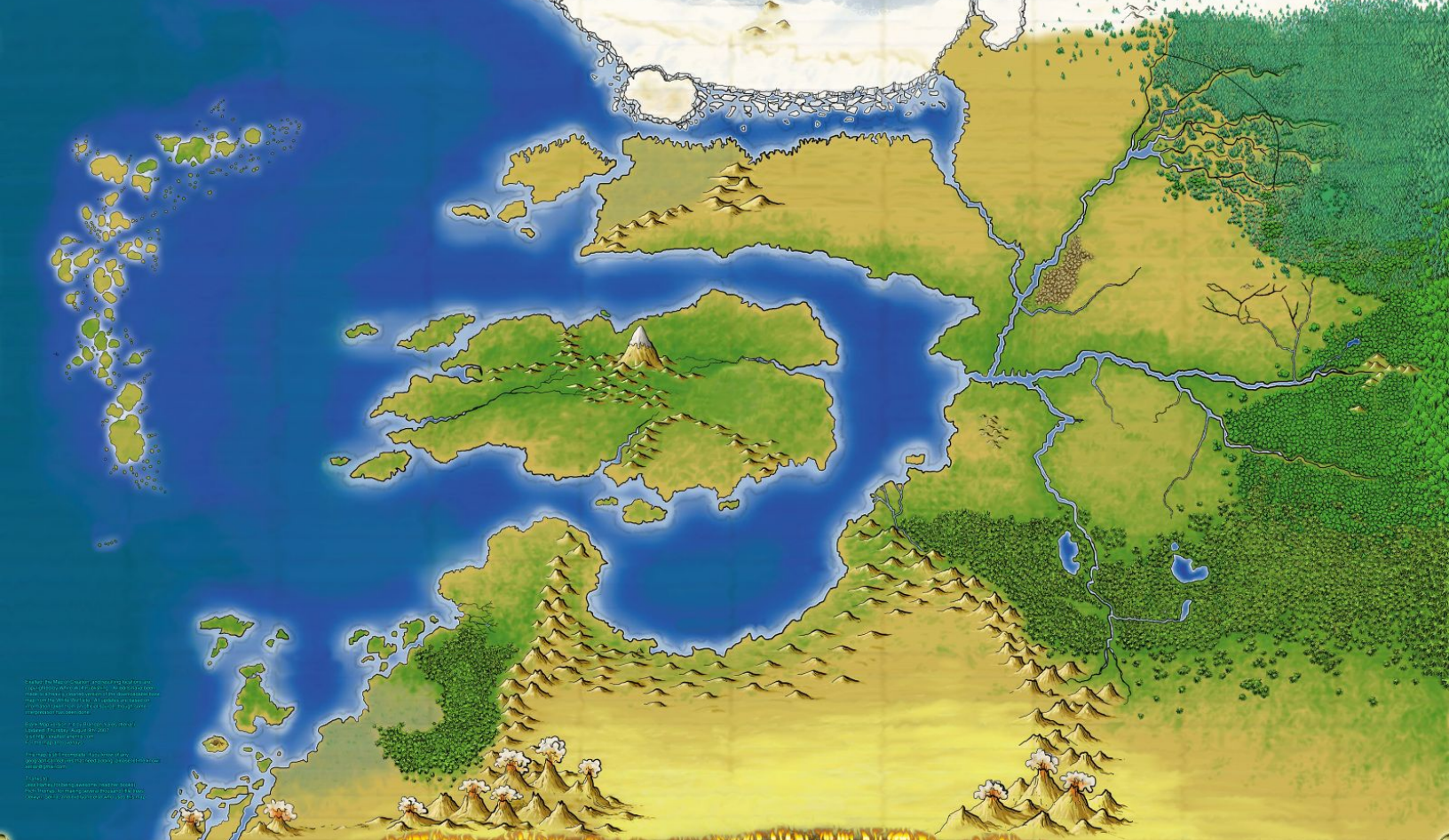
Most uniquely, these new beings were multitudinous in nature, each existing not merely as a single being but as a nation of smaller souls, interconnected and interdependent.

At the bottom were the **First Circle Devas**, countless in number but low in power and simple in nature. These were most comparable to the Fair Folk.

Next up from them were the **Second Circle Devas**, each one representing and commanding a specific group of First Circle Devas. While only the next tier up, the power of these Second Circle Devas was nearly incomprehensible to the lower souls.

Next up from them were the **Third Circle Devas**, each one representing and commanding exactly seven Second Circle Devas. The chief Third Circle Deva in each group was known as the **Fetich Soul**, and was thought of as the lord and head of the entire being. Together, a group of First, Second, and Third Circle Devas made up a single being known as a **Primordial**, or "*Titan*".

The first Primordials were *Cytherea, the Mother of Inspiration*, and *Oramus, The Dragon Beyond the World*. Not much is known about them, but others soon followed. There was *Theion, The Empyrean Tyrant*, who embodied the concept of Authority. There was *She Who Lives In Her Name*, who embodied the concept of Hierarchy. There was *Gaia, The Earth Mother*, who embodied the concept of Life. There was *Autochthon, The Great Maker*, who embodied the concept of Creativity. There was *The Dragon's Shadow*, who embodied the concept of Defiance. And there were many others, far too many to name here.



Creation

The Primordials hated the Wyld, and finally, they decided to do something about it. They would build themselves a world, bound in form by space and time, safe from the Unshaped and the questing Raksha and the ravages of Deep Chaos.

Gaia gave her body to be its substance. Her Third Circle Devas were forged by Autochthon into the *Elemental Poles* of Earth, Fire, Water, Air and Wood. Her Second Circle Devas became the **Dragons**, and her First Circle Devas became the **Elementals**, guardians of this newly anchored reality against the chaos and Raksha of the Wyld.

Autochthon also constructed his finest masterpiece, the **Loom of Fate**, to maintain the laws of causality, weaving the strands of the future into the tapestry of the past.

Between the Elemental Poles and the Loom of Fate, a bubble of solid reality was carved out of the Wyld, governed by set laws of physics and magic – maintained and enforced by countless little gods and spirits – rather than the whims of narrative and chaos. This was known as **Creation**.

For eons, the Primordials lived in Creation, caring for it, maintaining the Loom and the Elemental Poles, fighting back the forces of chaos at its borders. During this time, Gaia and Autochthon created many interesting creatures – **Beasts** and **Giants** and **Dragon Kings** and numerous other forms of life. The other Primordials found these lifeforms interesting as toys and playthings, but otherwise didn't much care.

One day, Autochthon created a new masterpiece: the first humanoid, known as *The Clay Man*. Proud of his work, he showed it off to his brother and sister Primordials, who found The Clay Man so interesting that they vivisected it for fun while Autochthon was forced to watch. Once they got bored, they left the remains of the Clay Man at the top of the Pole of Earth and moved on to other things.

Gaia felt compassion for her brother and his creation, and breathed life into the remains of the Clay Man, adding her *essence* to it and giving it a soul. This was the first **Human**, and with Gaia's help humanity spread all across Creation, becoming many nations.

As humans became more numerous, the other Primordials noticed something interesting. Humans were capable of something that no being before them had ever been: **worship**. They could generate *essence* for greater beings by venerating them and paying homage to them. In time, humanity created many great cults and religions centered around the Primordials, and in return some of these priests were granted favors in the form of magic and miracles.

The Incarnae

Eventually, the Primordials grew weary of maintaining this world they had created. They decided to forge new leaders from some of their highest Third Circle Devas, leaving them to look after Creation so that the Primordials could retire to **Yu Shan** (or "Heaven") and play *The Games of Divinity*.

Theion carved out his heart, making it into the king of all the gods. This was **Sol Invictus**, *The Unconquered Sun*, god of perfection and holy light. Removing his Fetich turned The Empyrean Tyrant into *Malfeas*, *The Demon King*.

Oramus and Cytherea set several of their Third Circle Devas to war with one another, and the one who ate all the others was made into **Luna**, *The Many-Faced*, god/dess of change and mischief.

None now remember the source of the *Fates*. At the moment of their creation, they spun backwards and forwards through time, seeming at once to have always existed. These were the **Five Sidereal Maidens**: *Mercury*, *Venus*, *Mars*, *Jupiter*, and *Saturn*, goddesses of time and destiny.



Together, Sol Invictus, Luna, and the Five Maidens were known as **The Celestial Incarnae**, though once the Primordials and their remaining souls retired from Creation, humanity came to think of the Incarnae simply as "the Gods". Some humans counted Gaia among the Gods as well, since, as her body made up the substance of Creation, she was unable to retire to Heaven with the other Primordials.

The Exalted

Now, the Primordials had created the Incarnae with safeguards in place to protect their own power. Being made from Primordial substance meant the Incarnae had some amount of inherent free will, but the Primordials made sure to bind and limit this will in subservience to their creators. The Incarnae were incapable of defiance, disobedience, or insurrection. They were the caretakers of Creation, and they were bound to this service.

The Incarnae grew weary of this enslavement, and plotted to overthrow their masters. As they were incapable of insurrection themselves, they had to create champions to fight the Primordials on their behalf. They conspired with Gaia and Autochthon, who were sympathetic to their cause, and together they created **The Shards of Exaltation**, fragments of Celestial Power that could be slotted into a human soul, granting that human the power of the Gods.

300 **Solar** Shards were created, mated to 300 **Lunar** Shards. 100 **Siderear** Shards were made as well, 20 for each of the Five Maidens.

In addition to these Celestial Shards, Gaia poured the blood of her Elemental Dragons into a nation of humans, creating a strain of Terrestrial Exaltation that could be spread through breeding.

These 700 **Celestial Exalted** and thousands upon thousands of **Dragonblooded** were outfitted by Autochthon with powerful armor and weapons of mass destruction, and together they marched on Heaven to fight the Titans.

The Primordial War

The war was long and bloody, costing the lives of countless souls on both sides. So much *essence* was flung back and forth that the Loom of Fate was barely able to compensate. Time and space were shattered, reforged, and shattered again many times over in this clash of heroes and Titans.

In the course of the battle, some Primordials were slain. But how do you kill an *idea*, the very embodiment of a concept? Though slain, these Titans were unable to die, and their undead bodies fell through the fabric of Creation, ripping through it and creating a dark reflection underneath. This became the **Underworld**, and the Titans who lay dead and dreaming within it became known as the **Neverborn**.

Even among the Primordials who survived, many suffered Fetich death, permanently altering their nature and identity. *Kai-Fa-Tek, Arbiter of the Infinite Covenant* became *Cecelyne, The Endless Desert*; *He Who Bleeds The Unknown Word* became *Elloge, The Sphere Of Speech*; *The Dragon's Shadow* became *The Ebon Dragon*; among many others.

Seeing the fate of their dying brethren, and not wishing to suffer further mutilation of self, the surviving Primordials surrendered. They swore binding oaths on their very names, vowing to be subservient to the Exalted just as they had once made the Incarnae subservient to them.

Malfeas was turned inside out, his body made the substance of an infinite prison, and the remaining Primordials were siphoned into him, sewing up the seams with the body of Cecelyne. This prison became known as **Hell**, the Titans trapped within were called the **Yozis**, and their Devas became known as **Demons**.

The First Age

Victorious, the Incarnae left Creation in the hands of their Exalted, retiring themselves to Heaven to play the Games of Divinity. But their victory had not been without cost.

In her last moments before being funneled into Malfeas, She Who Lives In Her Name threw a parting tantrum, stamping her foot in rage. The fires of this tantrum decimated Creation, burning nine tenths of it to ash that was quickly swept away into the chaos of the Wyld.

Despite this setback, the Exalted set to ruling and rebuilding what remained of Creation, and with the vast powers given to them by the Gods they established a golden age of prosperity.

New forms of magic and technology were discovered and developed. Great cities of stone and metal stretched high into the skies; leyline nodes were capped with **Manes** to harness their *essence* for automation; roads and airships connected cities across thousands and thousands of miles.

But it was not to last.

The Great Curse

Unbeknownst to anyone, the Neverborn, with their dying breaths, had laid a **Great Curse** upon their murderers. The Exalted, newly masters of all Creation, would slowly, subtly, over the course of centuries, be driven inevitably mad.

The Solar Exalted, meant to be divinely benevolent monarchs, became ruthless tyrants, warring with each other for sport, hunting many species to extinction including the Dragon Kings, performing brutal experiments on their own subjects to develop new magical technologies, which they used to better slaughter each other.

The Lunar Exalted, divine mates to the Solars and meant as the check and balance to their authority, became more and more submissive to their Solar mates, lapping at their heels as a pup to its master. As if that wasn't bad enough, they also gradually lost control of their shapeshifting, becoming mad mutated monstrosities known as **Chimera**. They were able to mitigate this dissolution by tattooing themselves with Moonsilver, but while this could delay the inevitable for centuries, it was not a perfect cure.

The Sidereal Exalted, meant to be the divine bureaucracy and keepers of fate and destiny, became embroiled in conspiracy and paranoia, hiding and lying and backstabbing for fear of being hidden from, lied to, and backstabbed.

The Terrestrial Exalted, meant to be the soldiers and police force under Solar command to maintain peace and order, became corrupt and selfish, seeking wealth and power for their own bloodline at everyone else's expense.

The Golden Age of Power was on a spiraling descent into bloody madness, with no end or solution in sight.

The Great Prophecy

A group of Sidereal Exalted, seeing this slow descent into madness in the Solars (but not in themselves) went to the Loom of Fate and performed the most significant act of astrological divination to date. This became known as **The Great Prophecy**, and it showed three possible outcomes:

The Vision of Bronze showed a future where the Sidereals overthrew the Solar kings and took on the mantle of authority for themselves. The golden age would end and Creation would be crippled, but not broken. Life could be peaceful and pleasant, if not as glorious as it once was.

The Vision of Gold showed a future where the Sidereals intervened on the Solars' behalf, bringing the madness to their attention and working with them to find the source of the madness and quash it, returning Creation to its golden age of prosperity. This vision cautioned, however, that such an outcome, while possible, was not guaranteed, and carried a high risk of failure.

The Vision of Darkness showed a future where the Sidereals did nothing, or where they sought the Vision of Gold but failed. In this vision, Creation descended unimpeded into madness and destruction, and ultimately became unable to sustain life or itself. The Loom of Fate would fail, the protected bubble of reality would pop, and shaped existence would be swept away into the chaos of the Wyld, or worse, sucked down through the Void into **Oblivion**.

The Sidereals debated endlessly among themselves about which vision to pursue.

The *Gold Faction* argued that the Solars had power and wisdom enough to find the source of madness and cure it if only they could be made aware of it, and that the glories of the golden age were worth fighting to maintain.

The *Bronze Faction* argued that pursuing the Vision of Gold was too great a risk. With only mad Solars to help them and no guarantee of success, they could very well be dooming all of Creation to the Vision of Darkness.

Everyone on both sides agreed, however, that the one thing they could not afford to do was nothing.

The Usurpation

In the end, the Bronze Faction won out. The Sidereals worked in secret with Autochthon and high ranking Dragonblooded to construct what became known as **The Jade Prison**. After helping with its construction, Autochthon, worried about Solar retribution should the plan fail (or Sidereal corruption should the plan succeed), took those humans loyal to him and fled with them to **Elsewhere**.

The Sidereals and their conspiring Dragonblooded held a great banquet in the Solars' honor, inviting all 300 of them to be there. Much high level magic was used to obscure the purpose of this banquet from the Solar seers' prying eyes, and against all odds, the plan worked. The Sidereals and Dragonblooded ambushed their Solar overlords at the banquet, and in a bloody massacre, slaughtered them all.

The Solar Shards of Exaltation, which should have gone to the *Wheel of Reincarnation* for cleaning and then sped out to find new hosts, were instead drawn into the Jade Prison and trapped. The Lunars who weren't killed in the battle alongside their Solar masters fled to the **Bordermarches** where Creation fades into the Wyld and lived in hiding there among the **Wyld Barbarians** and **Beastfolk**.



The Shogunate and the Immaculate Order

Rather than take public thrones, the Sidereals chose to rule from the shadows in secret, setting up their Dragonblooded generals as figureheads. One Sidereal went so far as to break the *Mask*, causing everyone besides the Sidereals and the Gods themselves to forget that such a thing as the Sidereal Exalted had ever existed at all. While not all Sidereals agreed this was the right move, nobody could figure out how to fix it, or even which one of them had done it, so they chose to accept the *Broken Mask* and work within its paradigm.

With the Solars trapped, the Lunars in hiding, and the Sidereals forgotten, the reconstruction of Creation fell to the Dragonblooded. They founded a religion known as **The Immaculate Order**, venerating the Elemental Dragons as the highest of gods – with the Dragonblooded just below them being the rightful rulers of Creation – and maintaining a **Terrestrial Bureaucracy** promoting the worship of smaller local gods rather than the Celestial Incarnae, who, along with their Celestial Exalted, were deemed **Anathema**.

Unfortunately, these Immaculate Dragonblooded did not have the raw power or godly ingenuity necessary to maintain the glories of the First Age. Many airships, automata, warstriders, factory cathedrals, and other technomantic glories fell into disuse and disrepair without their Solar inventors there to maintain them.

Without the central leadership of the Solar Council, Creation fragmented along family lines, with Dragonblooded Shoguns seizing local power and warring with bordering city states for territory and resources. Life for the Shoguns and their armies was bloody and hectic, but life for the common folk came to a mostly peaceful banality.

The Vision of Bronze had come to pass.

The Great Contagion and the Balorian Crusade

The Shogunate, though less glorious than the First Age, still oversaw several centuries of relative peace and prosperity.

But this, too, was not to last.

Without the Solars maintaining Creation's High First Age defenses, two massive incursions happened at roughly the same time, from two entirely disparate sources. Whether one was capitalizing on the other or whether this was simply a devastating coincidence is left for historians to guess.

First was **The Great Contagion**, a plague of undeath created by the servants of the Neverborn. Before the Primordial War, there was no undeath; souls went to the Wheel of Reincarnation and then returned as new life. But when the Neverborn fell through Creation and opened up the Underworld, some souls began to linger there instead.

When the Solars were massacred in the Usurpation, thirteen of their souls lingered in the Underworld. These became the **Deathlords**, powerful servants of the Neverborn, and it was they who engineered the Great Contagion. This plague spread across Creation, killing millions and creating **Shadowlands**, where Creation and the Underworld overlap.

At the same time as the Great Contagion, a powerful Raksha Noble named Balor incited the armies of the Wyld into the most massive invasion of Creation ever attempted. This became known as the **Balorian Crusade**, and the borders of Creation were overrun by the armies of chaos. Many Dragonblooded and the surviving Lunars attempted to keep the Wyld armies at bay, but with the death plague and new Shadowlands to contend with at the same time, they could not halt the inexorable spread of Chaos.

The Sidereals looked on in horror and confusion, many afraid that, in spite of the Usurpation, the dreaded Vision of Darkness had come at last.



The Scarlet Empress

While all of Creation struggled against the Raksha and undead, an unknown Dragonblooded soldier infiltrated the *Imperial Manse*, which had lay abandoned since the end of the Solar Council. No Dragonblooded or even Sidereal had yet found a way to bypass the First Age Solar security system guarding the place, but somehow this lone soldier succeeded where all before her had failed.

From within the Imperial Manse, she activated Creation's First Age Defense Grid, powering on the *Reality Engines* and *Essence Cannons* and taking direct control of them for herself. With these First Age wonders of technomancy at her disposal, she singlehandedly eradicated the Great Contagion and drove the Balorian Crusade back to the Wyld.

There were stragglers, of course, but the main forces were routed, and the crisis was averted. This soldier declared herself **The Scarlet Empress**, ruler of all Creation, and who among the survivors could argue? She ruled over Creation from the Imperial Manse for hundreds of years, siring a **Scarlet Dynasty** and ruling much longer than even a Dragonblooded should be able to survive, appearing not to have aged a day since taking power.

The Wyld Hunt

Despite the Imperial Defense Grid driving back the main forces of the Wyld and eradicating the Great Contagion, there were Fair Folk stragglers and Shadowlands full of new undead to be found all across Creation. And so the Scarlet Empress founded the **Wyld Hunt**, an elite squad of Dragonblooded soldiers whose sole purpose was to root out and destroy all **Anathema**, meaning Celestial Exalted as decreed by the Immaculate Order but also including Fair Folk and undead and anything else deemed "unnatural" by the Scarlet Dynasty and the Immaculate Order.

The Realm

The Blessed Isle, or **The Realm**, is the center of Scarlet Dynasty authority. Here the Immaculate Order and the Wyld Hunt are in full power. Illegal worship is rare, because when it is found out it is severely punished.

In the **Scavenger Lands** (or "*Threshold*") to the east of the Blessed Isle, things are different. While many of the city states there are officially part of the Realm and pay tribute to the Scarlet Empress, the Wyld Hunt and the Immaculate Order do not have nearly as strong a presence there, and



enforcement of their doctrines are more lax. Some states, such as **Nexus** and **Lookshy**, even openly oppose the Realm, and are safe havens for those persecuted by the Wyld Hunt.

Lands even further out, nearer the Bordermarches at the edges of Creation, are home to even wilder folk. Entire colonies of Beastfolk and Wyld Barbarians (sometimes led by Lunar Exalted) can be found thriving together, worshiping their ancestors or unorthodox gods or even Raksha nobles.

The Disappearance and the Return

Five years ago, in **Realm Year 763**, the Scarlet Empress vanished during **Calibration**, a five-day period of darkness at the end of each year where the Loom of Fate is shut down for maintenance and the normal laws of physics and magic become malleable and chaotic. Nobody knows what happened to her or where she went, but ambitious Dragon-blooded all over the Blessed Isle have been plotting against and clashing with one another, pulling their military forces home to shore up their power. In so doing, they have brought the Realm's presence and military might in the Threshold to far less than it already was.

Thanks to this weakening of the Realm, several tragedies have befallen their forces in the Threshold: the Tepet Legions suffered a massive defeat to the forces of a barbarian Anathema called the Bull of the North; the city of Thorns was sacked by a Deathlord called the Mask of Winters, whose undead citadel Juggernaut now rests over the ruins in the slowly growing Shadowland there; among other tragedies and military defeats.

Perhaps most significantly, in the wake of these events the Yozis and the Neverborn conspired to enact the greatest heist ever perpetrated. They discovered the location of the Jade Prison, and constructed a Necrotech Behemoth designed to crack the prison and capture the Solar Shards stored inside, which The Ebon Dragon had found a way to harness and corrupt for their own use.

However, when the Behemoth struck the Jade Prison, instead of cracking, it shattered, sending Solar Exaltations flying in every direction. The Behemoth managed to capture half of them, but the other half flew out into the world to find mortal hosts, giving second breath to 150 new Solar Exalted.

Of the 150 that were captured, 50 were given to the Yozis and the other 100 given to the Neverborn. These became the **Infernal Exalted** (or "*Green Sun Princes*") and **Abyssal Exalted** (or "*Deathknights*"), servants of Hell and the Underworld as powerful as the newly returned Solars.

Who Are You?

Are you a mortal who has been given second breath as one of the newly returned Solar Exalted? Are you one of the Lunar Exalted, living in hiding at the borders of Creation? Are you one of the Sidereal Exalted, managing the bureaucracies of Heaven and Earth from behind the broken Mask? Are you perhaps one of the Dragonblooded, a Dynast of the Realm or an Outcaste in the Threshold? Are you an Abyssal or Infernal Exalt, managing the demands of your twisted Primordial overlords with the cries of the humanity that still lives in your soul? Are you one of the Godblooded, a mortal in whose veins runs the blood of a god, demon, elemental, or Exalt? Or are you simply a Heroic Mortal, ordinary but for your tenacity and will to work your desires upon the world?

Whoever you are, we wish you the best of luck in Creation.

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